

Streamlining IT Procurement: Automating Standard Laptop Orders with Flow Designer

ServiceNow Micro-Project

PHASE 1 | BRAINSTORMING & IDEATION PHASE

1. Brainstorming & Ideation Phase

1.1 Background

IT departments regularly receive requests for standard, pre-approved hardware such as laptops. In many organizations this "should be simple" request still passes through several manual hand-offs: the requester raises a ticket, someone manually creates a configuration task, someone manually assigns it to the hardware team, and someone manually updates the request once approved. Each hand-off is a place where a request can sit untouched, get mis-routed, or simply be forgotten — especially for a request type that is, by definition, standard and repetitive and therefore a strong automation candidate.

1.2 Problem Statement

The current IT procurement process lacks efficiency and automation, resulting in delays and manual overhead, particularly in handling standard laptop orders. Requests for standard laptops often require configuration, but this step is prone to oversight or delay, leading to frustration among users and inefficient resource allocation within the IT department.

1.3 User Story

"As a member of the IT procurement team, I want a streamlined process for ordering standard laptops so that tasks are automatically generated and assigned to the hardware team for configuration. This will ensure that laptops are promptly configured upon arrival, reducing user wait times and minimising manual intervention."

1.4 Ideas Explored

Option Considered	Description	Verdict
Manual task creation by the IT team	Continue letting a staff member manually raise a Catalog Task and assign it after every approved request.	Rejected — this is the exact bottleneck the project must remove; it does not scale and is the direct cause of delays.
Legacy Workflow (Workflow Editor)	Use ServiceNow's classic Workflow engine, attached to the catalog item's Process Engine.	Rejected — Workflow is a legacy/graphical engine being phased out in favor of Flow Designer, and lacks the simpler, reusable action-based model needed here.
Business Rule on sc_req_item	Write a server-side Business Rule that fires on approval and inserts a Catalog Task record directly.	Rejected as primary approach — possible, but harder to maintain/visualize than a flow, and mixes automation logic into scripted business rules rather than a low-code, auditable flow.
Flow Designer automation (chosen)	Build a Flow triggered by the Service Catalog request, which creates a Catalog Task pre-populated with description and Assignment group once the request is Approved, and attach it as the item's Process Engine.	Selected — native low-code automation tool, purpose-built for catalog fulfillment, easy to visualize/maintain, and directly assignable to a catalog item.

1.5 Why Flow Designer Was Chosen

- **Native catalog integration:** Flow Designer has a dedicated "Service Catalog" trigger and can be wired directly into a catalog item's *Process Engine*, so it runs automatically the moment a request is placed.
- **Low-code, auditable:** Actions such as "Create Catalog Task" are pre-built, testable, and visually represented — easier to review and hand over than raw script.
- **Field automation:** The flow can pre-fill Short Description, Description, Assignment group, and Approval status on the generated Catalog Task, eliminating manual data entry.
- **Extensible:** The same flow pattern can later be reused for other standard hardware/software catalog items with minimal changes.

1.6 Initial Scope Ideas

In scope	Out of scope
• One Flow ("Standard Laptop task") triggered by Service Catalog • Auto-creation of a Catalog Task with description & Assignment group = Hardware • Attaching the flow to the "Standard Laptop" catalog item's Process Engine • End-to-end verification: order → approval → task creation	• Automated hardware inventory / stock checks • Multi-level approval chains • Notifications/emails to the requester on task completion • Automation for non-standard or custom-configured laptops

1.7 Ideation Outcome

The brainstorming session converged on building a **Flow Designer automation** that listens for a Service Catalog request, and — once approved — automatically creates and assigns a pre-filled Catalog Task to the Hardware team. This directly targets the manual-overhead pain point identified in the problem statement and sets the direction for the requirement, design, and development phases that follow.